No.14 The Woman's Rose

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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The Woman's Rose analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to The Woman's Rose by Olive Schreiner contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of The Woman's Rose

Olive Schreiner was a South African writer, born in 1855. Her short story, The Woman's Rose, published in 1891, focuses on female relationships, particularly within a male-dominated society.

It opens with the **first-person** narrator describing a wooden box. The box contains precious keepsakes, which include a faded white rose. The rose reminds her of a significant moment in her past, which the narrator goes on to relate.

As a teenage girl, she visited a small town. The settlement was largely dominated by men, and there was only one other woman of similar age to the narrator living there. The woman was beautiful and attracted the men's attention. However, when the narrator arrived, the men's affections and attention suddenly moved away from the woman and towards her. She explains that this placed a barrier between the two women. Instead of becoming friends and allies, they did not speak to each other. In fact, the men's behaviour created a sense of rivalry between them.

The night before she left the town, a party was held. It was at this party she and the woman finally spoke to each other. The woman placed a rare white rose (taken from her own blonde

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Although she never saw the woman again, the narrator explains that whenever she feels a sense of despair, she looks at the rose and remembers their friendship, and this brings her strength and renews her hope.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. This will help you to form a structural analysis, which means you will be considering how themes and characters develop (or not) through the story.

Themes, ideas and perspectives in The Woman's Rose

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Olive Schreiner's The Woman's Rose.

What are the key themes in The Woman's Rose?

Theme	Analysis

Gender	• Schreiner raises ideas about **patriarchal** attitudes by setting her story in a town that "consisted mainly of men":
	  ○ The narrator says that the young men in the town "worshipped" the woman with "light" hair, and then later, her
	• The story describes a young teenage girl who quickly decides that the men around her make **superficial** romantic gestures:
	  ○ They are "simply a fashion, which one man had set and the rest followed unreasoningly"
	  ○ She says the men always look for someone "new"
	• Schreiner illustrates how the men's comparison of the women's beauty creates a sense of rivalry:
	  ○ The narrator compares her looks to the woman with "dreamy blue eyes" and says the woman is "prettier"

	◦ By the end, the women form a bond by complementing each other on their appearance, and rejecting the men ◦ The narrator describes how she threw away the flowers given to her by a man, but kept the rose
Hope	• Schreiner raises the theme of hope through a symbolic "rose": ◦ The "scent of that dead rose, withered for twelve years" brings back a significant memory to the narrator • Schreiner suggests that sisterhood brings strength: ◦ When she finds the female experience a struggle, the rose reminds her that "there will be spring" ◦ She compares looking at the rose to when birds "see above the snow two tiny, quivering green leaves" ◦ This implies female friendship is fragile, but offers hope

Writer's methods in The Woman's Rose

How does Schreiner present her ideas and perspectives?

Schreiner's story The Woman's Rose is an **allegory** about male and female relationships and the idea of female solidarity.

Technique	Analysis
Symbolism	• Schreiner's story uses a "withered" rose (a keepsake) to symbolise female friendship and to suggest it is rare and precious • The rose is described as special: ◦ On the rose bush there was only "one bud. It was white" ◦ The short sentence brings attention to the symbolic colour, alluding to the friendship as a pure, genuine connection • Schreiner uses **imagery** connoting to light to describe the memory of the woman with "bright hair glittering in the candle-light": ◦ The woman who gives the rose to the narrator is dressed in "pure white, with her great white arms and shoulders showing"

	• The story ends connecting the rose with the season of spring:
	  ○ "The scent of that small withered thing comes back:—spring cannot fail us"
	  ○ While the rose represents sisterhood, "spring" alludes to hope

Flashback	• Schreiner's **first-person** narrator begins the story in the present tense:
	  ○ "I have an old, brown carved box"
	  ○ This gives the intimate monologue a sense of immediacy
	• The significance of memory is introduced as a theme in the short sentence "I have in it a rose"
	• The return to a moment when the narrator was fifteen years old allows Schreiner to discuss gender dynamics through the eyes of an innocent girl:
	  ○ The flashback begins "It is many years ago now; I was a girl of fifteen"
	  ○ This gives the allegory a sense of poignant naivete

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners have said that the best answers to the prose question on the CIE Literature in English Paper 1, focus on the authors' choices of language and literary methods, and the effects these might have on a reader.

You will be rewarded for a thoughtful argument that is closely supported by detailed references to the text, and analysis of the writer's choices. For instance, in Olive Schreiner's short story The Woman's Rose, a rose symbolises female solidarity: the support and sense of connection that can be found in female relationships.

Key quotations in The Woman's Rose

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. Remember, though, summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referencing plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

arranged by the following themes:

- **Gender**
- **Hope**

Gender

Schreiner's story criticises **fickle** and **superficial** attitudes to female beauty through her presentation of a teenage girl in a male-dominated world. At the same time, the story depicts how two women's shared experiences of male rivalry bring them together.

> **"When my eye is dim, and my heart grows faint, and my faith in woman flickers, and her present is an agony to me, and her future a despair, the scent of that dead rose, withered for twelve years, comes back to me" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- The adult narrator says that they are sometimes confused and weakened
- When their belief in women wavers ("flickers"), or when life is painful and the future desperate, the smell of a "dead rose" helps them find strength
- Even though the rose is "withered" and dead, the smell comes back, and this reminds them of a significant moment 12 years before

Analysis

- Schreiner uses polysyndeton to emphasise the many times the narrator feels distressed by the female experience:
  - Sensory **imagery** contrasts the "scent" of a rose with the idea of death
  - This dramatic line presents heightened emotions

> **"But I was vital, and I was new, and she was old — they all forsook her and followed me" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- The narrator remembers how the men shifted their attentions from the woman with the "light" hair to her when she arrived in the new town
- She says it was because she was someone fresh whom they had never seen
- She says they "forsook" (abandoned) the woman and "followed" her instead

Analysis

    - The narrator, aged 15, calls the 17-year-old "old", which highlights how quickly women were judged by appearance and novelty, while also reflecting her naive, adolescent perspective

- The word "old", though, has been explicitly used to contrast "new", suggesting the men got bored of the woman and she has now lost her value:
    - In contrast, the narrator is a novelty to them

> **"I despised them" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- The narrator remembers how the male rivalry over the women, and their superficial affection towards her, made her hate them

Analysis

- Schreiner's story expresses the thoughts and feelings of an honest, young girl
- The short sentence emphasises the extreme reaction to the men's actions
- This presents a harsh criticism of male and female relationships

Hope

> **"Other women also have such boxes where they keep such trifles, but no one has my rose" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- Looking in a special wooden box of keepsakes, the narrator says that lots of women have a place to keep memorable objects
- She says, though, that her rose is special, and unique to her

Analysis

- Schreiner begins her story by indicating the significance of the rose
- This creates suspense, and highlights the importance of the rose's story

> **"She was dressed in pure white, with her great white arms and shoulders showing, and her bright hair**

Meaning and context

- The narrator describes the woman she meets at her going-away party
- The woman was in "white", wore a "white rose", and had pale skin
- Her hair was shining in the soft light

Analysis

- Schreiner's **imagery** alludes to purity and light to present the woman as innocent and angelic, which signifies the woman's influence
- Her "white" dress and "bright hair" contrasts with the narrator who is described with dark hair and in an "old black dress"
- This highlights the initial disconnect between the women and shows them as rivals in oppositional positions

> **"When my faith in woman grows dim, and it seems that for want of love and magnanimity she can play no part in any future heaven; then the scent of that small withered thing comes back:—spring cannot fail us" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- The narrator repeats similar ideas at the beginning and end of her story
- As she comes to the end of her memory, back in present day, she concludes that the rose, a "small, withered thing" has great power:
    - At times, when she loses faith, feels no love and generosity of spirit, and sees no future in "heaven", she remembers the rose
- The rose reminds her that there is always spring after winter, and, thus, hope

Analysis

- Schreiner's story is cyclical in nature:
    - It begins and ends with the narrator looking at the dead rose the woman gave her when she was a teenager
    - The story shows the timeless power of memory by evoking the smell of a "withered" rose
- The symbolism of "spring" is used throughout the story to represent hope and rebirth:
    - Schreiner draws connections between the reliability of the changing seasons and the ever-lasting power of the rose to represent the female bond

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in*

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